DR KRITHI K. KARANTH, 47
Conservation scientist
Bengaluru

Guardian of the Wild

For someone who first accompanied her father, the acclaimed tiger biologist Dr Ullas Karanth, into the jungles at age two, it was not until she was studying for a master's at Yale University that Krithi Karanth actually made up her mind about a career in conservation. Twenty-two at the time, it was a research project at Bhadra Wildlife Sanctuary in the Karnataka section of the Western Ghats that sealed her decision. The big break came in 2011 when she received a grant from the National Geographic Society for research into human-animal conflict. "When an organisation like that finds you, it boosts your profile, gives you the confidence to dream more, ask bolder questions," she says. "It changes your career trajectory."

Today, national parks and wildlife sanctuaries cover only 5 per cent of India's land area, far lower than the 15 per cent in countries such as the US and China. This needs to go up to at least 10 per cent, says Krithi, CEO of the Bengaluru-based non-profit Centre for Wildlife Studies (CWS) that her father set up in 1984. "We can do this by 2050," she adds. "There are imaginative ways to bring those numbers up." Since Krithi took over in 2018, CWS has expanded its scale of operations. It now works extensively in 100 parks in eight states, while its education programmes have reached 75,000 middle school children in villages around wildlife parks. The CWS training programmes focus on building foundational knowledge amongst key stakeholders such as forest departments, frontline staff, veterinary services, the police and fire services. ■

— Ajay Sukumaran

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

The 2026 Indian Rolex National Geographic Explorer of the Year, Krithi's work spans human–wildlife coexistence, education and conservation



ANIRUDDH KAUSHAL

HER TAKE

"It's okay to fail, but pick yourself back up, be supremely resilient. That is the only way you are going to have a long, impactful career. A lot of people get disheartened by failure. I think I have learnt the most from failing"